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The

Rise of

Esports

“Esports have become a real profession, and people should start treating it like one” (Riot Games). According to The Oxford English Dictionary (OED), Esports are multiplayer games played competitively by professional gamers for spectators. The ‘E’ in Esports stands for ‘electronic’. In 1958, physicist William Higinbotham created the first video game, which was a simple tennis game. Later, in the seventies and early eighties, the golden age of arcade games began. In 1972, the first competitive gaming event was organized by Stanford University, named *Spacewar*, which marked the beginning of Esports (Kent, 2001). The nineties gave a strong boost to Esports because of the development of personal computers (PCs) and the evolution of the internet through the LAN network, also known as the local area network. Due to LAN, people went from human-vs-machine gameplay to human-vs-human gameplay. In the 1990s, the invention of internet games like *Quake* and *StarCraft* popularized online competition. By 2010, global tournaments were being organized for games like *The International (Dota 2)* and *League of Legends*. Today, Esports have become a billion-dollar industry, with tournaments filling arenas and attracting millions of viewers online (Statista, 2024). This essay will discuss the rise of Esports. The global esports market is projected to generate over \$1 billion in revenue in 2024 (Statista, 2024). Firstly, the essay will explain why Esports gained popularity, secondly, the essay will illustrate a relation between traditional sports and Esports, and lastly the essay will outline how Esports is growing with respect to traditional sports.

Esports have gained rapid growth and popularity over the past few years. It can be claimed that one of the main reasons for this growth and popularity is the improvement in gaming

technology and internet connectivity. According to McIntosh (2023), the development of high-speed internet and advanced gaming technology has made it easier for players to connect globally without long delays, allowing competitive gaming to thrive, attracting larger audiences worldwide. The development of Esports started in the 1990s because of the creation of LAN cables. LAN cables enabled two humans to play together in real time. Before that, people used to play alone or against a machine. Games like *Quake* and *StarCraft* became popular during that time. These games not only offered players a chance to compete against each other but also encouraged them to improve their skills and be part of communities (Esports.net, 2021). As the internet continued to develop, high-speed internet connections became more common, allowing gamers all over the world to connect and compete easily. This enabled players to play multiplayer games without long delays or interruptions (McIntosh, 2023). Another main factor in the rise of Esports is the role of live-streaming platforms like Twitch. In the past, if someone wanted to watch gameplay, they needed to be present in the same room as the gamer or watch recorded gameplay. But with the development of streaming technology, people can watch the live broadcasts of the game from anywhere in the world. Twitch has made it easier to watch players, teams, tournaments, and interact with other viewers who share the same interest. This has helped Esports create a global community with large audiences, where viewers can watch together, share opinions, and cheer for their favourite teams (Taylor, 2012). According to Statista, the number of minutes watched on twitch reached more than 1.3 trillion in year 2022. In conclusion, the growth of Esports is achieved because of the development of advanced technology in internet connectivity and streaming platforms. These factors have allowed Esports to change from a small hobby to a global industry. The combination of better gaming technology and the rise of online streaming platforms have made Esports more accessible, exciting, and popular.

Traditional sports and Esports are both famous these days, and they are often compared to each other. It can be argued that Esports share several elements with traditional sports, including teamwork, competition, and skill requirements. According to T.L. Taylor (2012), Esports events have adopted many characteristics of traditional sports, such as teamwork, strategic planning, and intense skill development, as players work together to win in competitive tournaments. Just like traditional sports, Esports also involve global tournaments, professional players, and cheering fans. For example, games like *League of Legends*, *Dota 2*, and *Valorant* require players to coordinate with each other, make strategies, and take right actions under pressure. This is like traditional sports such as football or cricket. According to T.L. Taylor (2012), Esports events have adopted many things from traditional sports, like professional coaches, referees, and professional players who dedicate hours to training to maintain peak performance and follow strict rules. Teamwork is important in both traditional sports and Esports. In Esports, players specialize in roles in which they are appointed. Football has roles like forwards and defenders or baller and batsmen in cricket. The roles in Esports are also similar; for example, in *Valorant*, there are roles like damage dealers and supporters. Jenny et al. (2007) highlight how professionally Esports teams hire coaches and analysts to improve team performance, which is similar to traditional sports. Additionally, in traditional sports and Esports, the audience is passionate. Fans of both attend live events, wear team jerseys or merchandise, create communities, and stream matches together. Streaming platforms like Twitch have become like virtual stadiums, where millions of people watch matches together, interact, and cheer for their favourite teams. Taylor (2012) explains that watching Esports is like watching traditional sports because fans come together to enjoy the games and share the excitement of the matches. Esports viewership continues to rise, with the global audience expected to surpass 640 million by 2024, showcasing its rapidly growing fan base, like traditional sports audiences (*Statista*, 2024). In conclusion, the relationship between traditional

sports and Esports lies in their shared competition, teamwork, and fan culture. These similarities in traditional sports and Esports have allowed Esports to gain acceptance and popularity similar to traditional sports.

Esports and traditional sports are closely connected in many ways, especially in their business models and fan engagement. It can be claimed that the growth of Esports is following a path similar to traditional sports, where sponsorships, tournaments, and audience interaction plays main roles. According to Jenny et al. (2007), Esports has adopted many elements from traditional sports, such as professional sponsorships, tournament structures, and fan engagement strategies, all of which contribute to its growing industry, much like in traditional sports. Companies like Intel, Red Bull, and Nike now sponsor Esports tournaments and teams, just like they do in traditional sports (Newzoo, 2023). These sponsorships bring in money for players and teams, helping Esports grow into a global industry. The Esports market is expected to earn \$1.8 billion in revenue by 2025, driven by sponsorships, ticket sales, and media rights (Newzoo, 2023). This shows how Esports is becoming more like traditional sports in terms of business and marketing. Another similarity is how both traditional sports and Esports engage with their fans. Esports events are streamed live on platforms like Twitch, where fans can watch their favourite players and interact with other viewers. This is similar to how fans watch traditional sports on TV or in stadiums, cheering for their favourite teams. According to Taylor (2012), Esports viewers experience the same excitement and sense of community as traditional sports fans. However, Esports also has its own unique culture. For example, players often use memes, jokes, and “trash talk” during games, which can confuse new fans. Commentators also use gaming-specific terms that may make it hard for people unfamiliar with Esports to fully understand what is happening (Jenny et al., 2007). While these challenges exist, the similarities between Esports and traditional sports show that both industries are about more than just competition. They are also about bringing people together. Esports has successfully adopted

strategies from traditional sports, like sponsorships and fan engagement, while creating its own identity in the gaming world. Hosting gaming tournaments or events is a big source of income for Esports players. In 2023, the League of Legends World Championship reached a peak concurrent viewership of 5.1 million, reflecting the massive global engagement Esports events attract (*Esports Charts, 2023*). In conclusion, the connection between traditional sports and Esports is strong, and as Esports continues to grow, it is expected to gain more respect and be as important as traditional sports.

This essay has explained in detailed how Esports became popular because of technology. The essay has illustrated how Esports connect to traditional sports. The essay has outlined that how Esports have gained popularity with respect to traditional sports. To sum up, Esports has become incredibly popular because of advancements in gaming technology and the rise of online streaming platforms like Twitch. These platforms have allowed Esports to grow globally. While Esports and traditional sports are different in terms of how they are played, they have a lot in common, such as competition, teamwork, and passionate fans. These shared elements has allowed Esports to borrow ideas from traditional sports, like professional coaching, sponsorships, and big tournaments. As the Esports industry keeps growing and attracting more attention, it is clear that it will soon be as well-respected and popular as traditional sports. As Esports continues to grow, it is expected to gain more respect and eventually be seen as just as important as traditional sports.

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